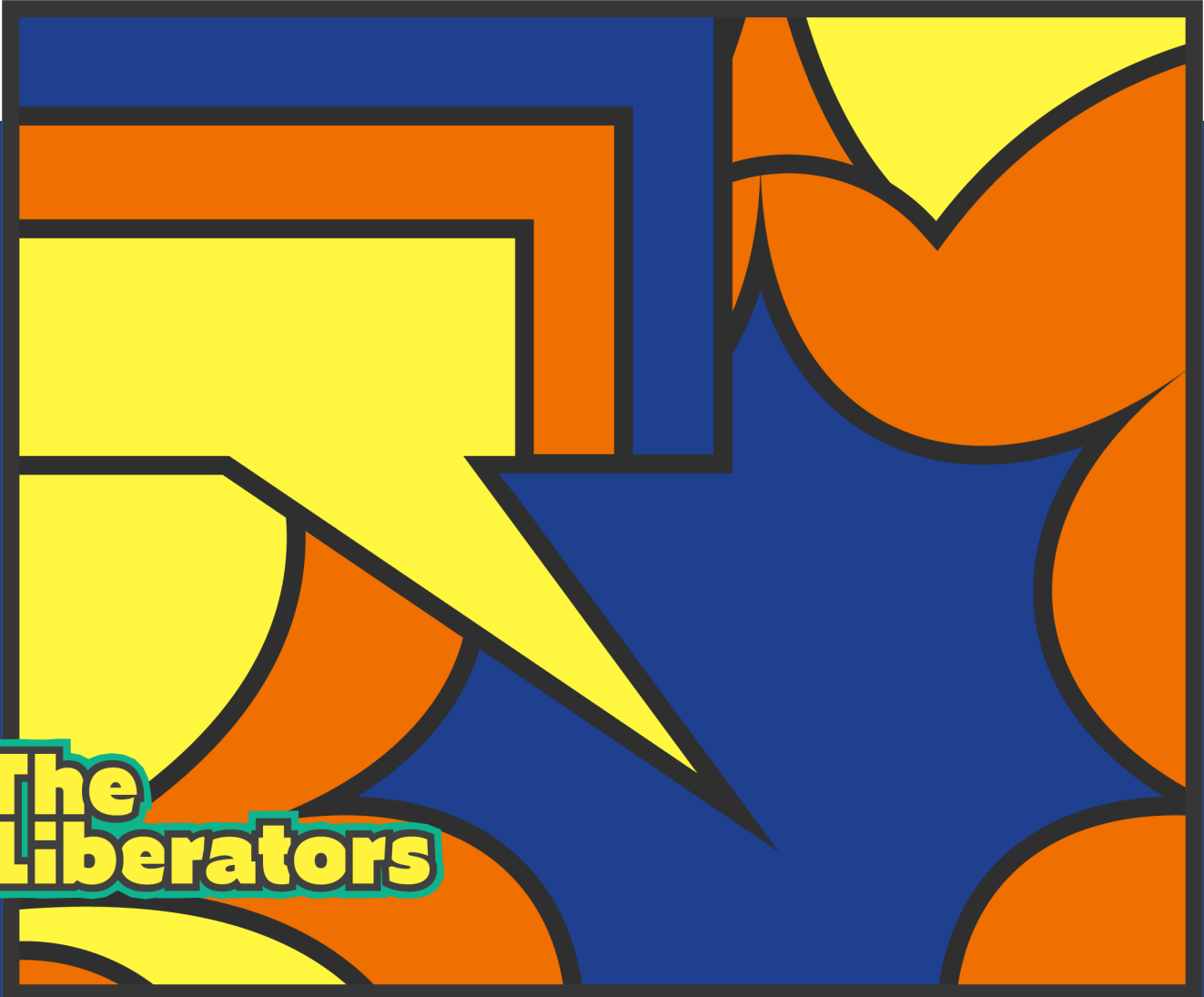


Help Your Team Get Started With A Definition Of Done

A do-it-yourself workshop to familiarize your team with the concept of a Definition of Done and to create the first version of their own



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

The Definition of Done defines what a high-quality Increment looks like for your team. It usually contains such criteria as "The code is covered by unit tests" or "Support documentation is available", or even "The language has been proofread by an editor". The more clear your team is about what quality means to them, the less rework and the more professional your results will be.

Creating and using a Definition of Done is easy and involves three steps:

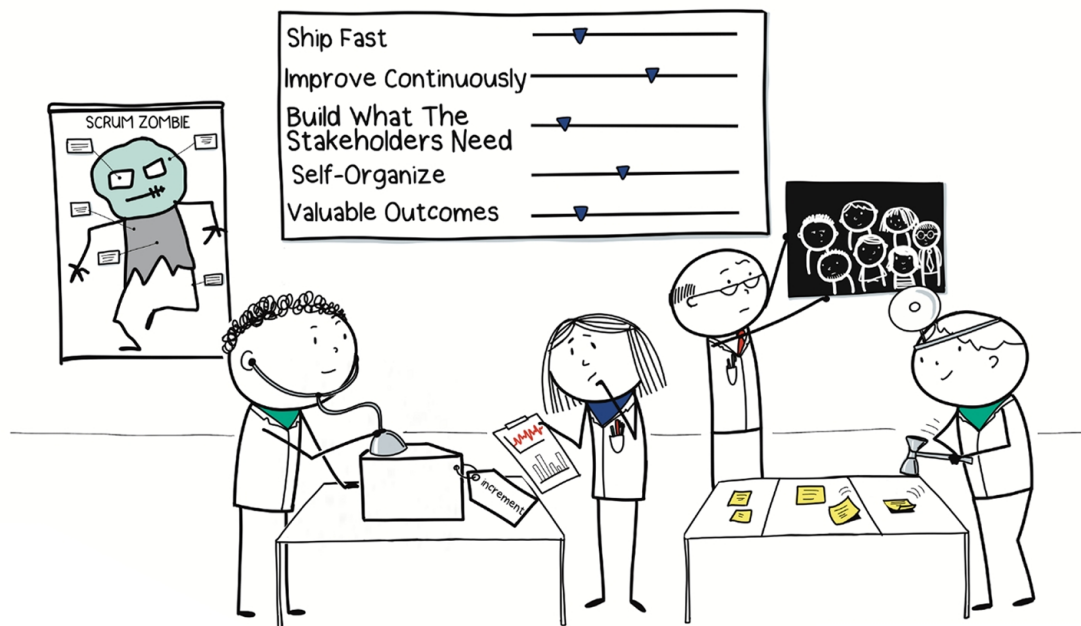
1. Create the Definition of Done
2. Use the Definition of Done
3. Take the Definition of Done to the next level

We created this do-it-yourself workshop to familiarize your team with the concept of a Definition of Done and to create the first version of their own. So, if you start with a new Scrum team, or your existing team decided to start using Scrum, run this workshop to create your Definition of Done. It's a vital step to kickstart your team in the best way possible!

Let's learn and grow, together!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
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Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Clarify What Quality Actually Means With "1-2-4-ALL"

  25 min

Step 3: Explain Why A Done Increment And The Definition Of Done Matter

 15 min

Step 4: Create A Definition Of Done With "Min Specs"

  45 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



The structures in the workshop are easy to facilitate. You might want to prepare your explanation of the Definition of Done to ensure it's clear and concise.

Impact On Survival



A Definition of Done is an important tool to guide the team on their way of building high-quality, kick-ass products.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to start using a Definition of Done. Run this workshop first with the team only, this includes the Scrum Master and Product Owner. Optionally, share the outcome with the stakeholders to gather feedback and make possible improvements.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Why Scrum requires completely "Done" software every Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Myth: In Scrum, new features are delivered only at the end of the Sprint](#)
- Podcast episode: [So, When Will It Be Done? And How Much Will It Cost?](#)



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.

Step 2: Clarify What Quality Actually Means With "1-2-4-ALL"

Before you introduce and explain the concept of a Definition of Done, it's good to have the team's thinking first get started about quality in general. How would they describe quality? What does quality mean for their team? How do we know that our work lives up to our quality standards?

The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is ideally suited to help the team quickly share their thoughts. If you like, capture insights on a shared workspace.

Invitation

"How would you describe what quality means for our team? How do we know that our work lives up to our quality standards?"

Steps

1.  Ask everyone to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and write down what comes to mind.
2.  Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3.  Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4.  Together, collect the key ideas in a shared workspace.

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)



Step 3: Explain Why A Done Increment And The Definition Of Done Matter

In the previous step, the team got their thinking started about what quality actually is, what it means, and how they currently know they're living up to their quality standards. In this step, you introduce the concept of a Definition of Done and explain how it helps teams to create a shared understanding about quality, to increase predictability, and to manage risk.

Steps

- **5 min** Explain why a Done Increment matters and how having a Definition of Done helps to achieve it. Draw inspiration from the text and the illustration we've included. Try to keep it short, clear, and concise.
- **10 min** Answer questions that need clarification before the group moves into the next step, Min Specs.

The Purpose Of Scrum

If you were to capture the purpose of the Scrum framework in a single sentence, it would be to work empirically by delivering a Done Increment at least once every Sprint. This is also why it is so important that Scrum teams spend time clarifying what is involved in creating an increment that is Done. What work is required to do this? Which checks and tests are necessary to conform to our internal quality guidelines? Who needs to be involved in this? This shared understanding is called the **Definition of Done**, and it usually takes the form of a checklist.

The Risk Of Assumptions

The work on the Product Backlog tends to be chock full of assumptions until they are completed and put into the hands of users. For example, "Will implementing this item improve the experience of users?", "Will users understand how it works?", "Does it perform well enough?" Other assumptions will be about the work that needs to be done to implement the item, like "How easy will it be to test and deploy this item?", "What issues will we run into when working on this item?", "How well do we understand what to build?".

Every assumption represents a risk. The risk that you misunderstood what a user asked for and need to rework it. The risk that you run into technical limitations when you start writing the code. The risk is that the feature performs much worse than expected. The risk that writing automated tests turns out to be much harder. Or the risk of spending money and time on a feature that ends up not being used. What these risks all share is that they result in more and unexpected work somewhere down the line. And this kind of "carry-over" work has a tendency to be invisible until it pops up when you least expect it, messing up what you are working on in that Sprint. This is called "Un-done work".

How To Manage Risk

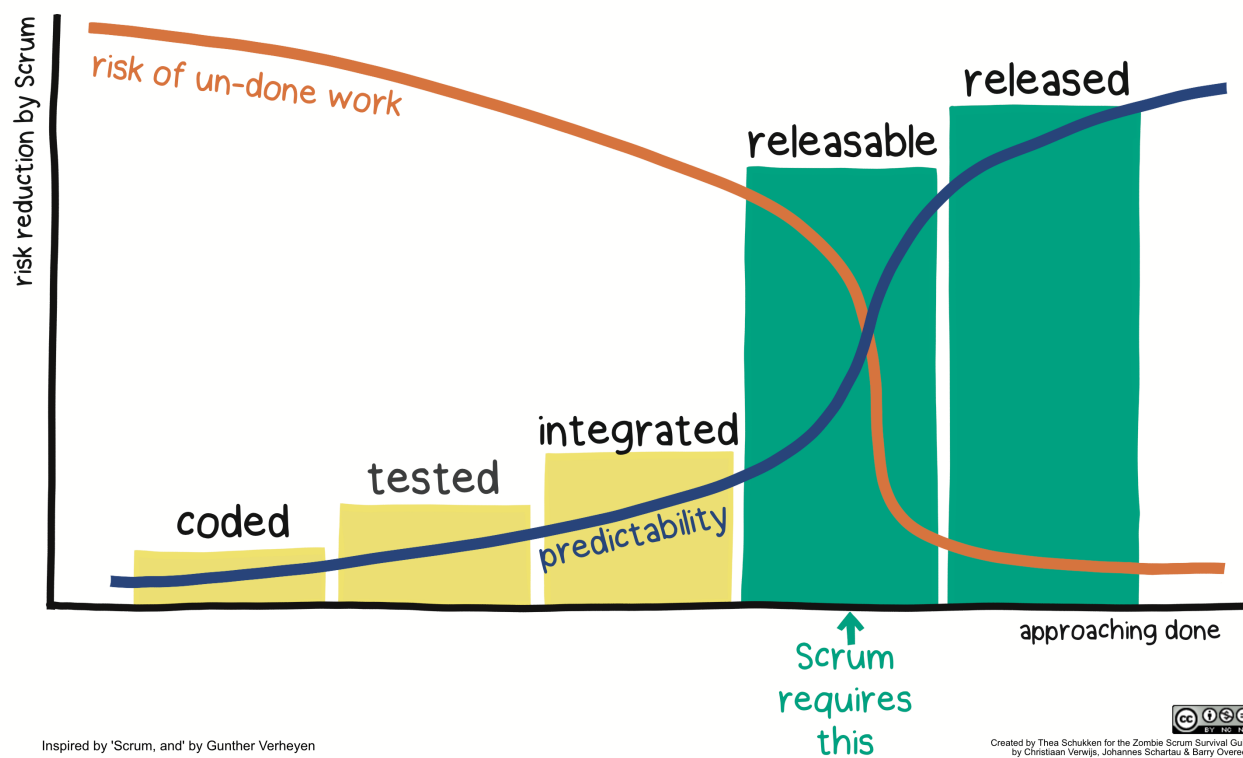
The best way to prevent the risk of un-done work is to make sure that each Sprint results – at least once – in a Done Increment that can be potentially released. That means that the Increment has been fully tested and is working. Texts and visuals are in their final state. Documentation and deployment packages are up-to-date. And performance and security conform to organizational standards. From here, the increment can be released to users with the proverbial press of a button. From this point onward, you know that there will be little to no potential un-done work that can mess up the focus and predictability of future Sprints. More importantly, it allows you to exercise empirical process control by releasing the increment to see if this moves your product closer to its ambitions, rather than assuming that it will.

Creating a Done Increment for every Sprint is certainly challenging. But purposefully so. Because putting this amount of pressure on the system that is creating the product – to do all the work necessary to achieve this – shows clearly where improvements are necessary. Where skills, tools, and technologies are missing. Where bureaucracy is getting in the way. Where impediments need to be removed in order to actually work empirically and reduce the risk of complex work. By keeping a laser focus on delivering a Done Increment at least once every Sprint, the system will start hurting in the right spots and create opportunities for inspection and adaptation.

In A Nutshell

So, if you need to explain this to your team, here are the key takeaways you should emphasize:

- The Scrum framework requires a useful, Done Increment at least once every Sprint. Only then can a Scrum team truly validate underlying assumptions with their stakeholders. Each Increment represents a step towards achieving the larger Product Goal;
- The Definition of Done makes explicit what the state of the Increment should be when it meets the quality measures required for the product. The Definition of Done applies to the Increment as a whole and to each Product Backlog item that is a part of that Increment. Work that does not meet the Definition of Done is not considered part of the Increment;
- As the Definition of Done becomes more comprehensive, the chance of problems popping up that require further time from the Scrum team decreases. This improves quality, predictability and lowers risks;
- Scrum teams that are unable to deliver Done Increments every Sprint are unable to truly reduce the risks that are inherent to complex work. Although they may already benefit from the rules of Scrum, they are not doing Scrum yet.
- When teams and organizations focus their efforts on delivering useful Done Increments every Sprint, they will rapidly discover what impedes their Agility. This can range from missing skills, obsolete technologies, dependencies to other organizational impediments;



Step 4: Create A Definition Of Done With "Min Specs"



Now that the team has a basic understanding of the Definition of Done, it is time to actually create one for themselves. It doesn't have to be perfect, just make sure it's a good starting point. Something that ensures them to deliver a high-quality product and is realistic enough to live up to.

We use the Liberating Structure [Min Specs](#) to give your team a clear structure to first think broadly about the rules of a Definition of Done, and then to narrow it down to the essential ones. It invites people to first think of all sorts of creative and outside-of-the-box ideas – and then funnels it back down to what is the most important.

Invitation

"What are the essential criteria we must honor to deliver a kick-ass, high-quality increment to our stakeholders each Sprint?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to individually and silently generate a list of rules the Definition of Done must contain.
2. **10 min** Invite people into small groups (2-4) or move them into breakouts if you're doing this virtually. Ask people to combine and expand their lists in their small groups.
3. **8 min** Invite people into small groups (3-5) and move them into separate breakouts. Together, they consolidate their lists and expand them to make them as long as possible (Max Specs).
4. **8 min** Bring everyone back to the main channel and explain the next step. Once they're back in their breakouts, ask the groups to test each of the items on their lists against the purpose statement. Let them ask: "Can we still be successful with this Scrum team if we broke this rule?". Each group removes all the items that aren't absolutely essential (Min Specs).
5. **8 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, collect the remaining rules on a shared workspace, removing duplicates and clarifying as needed.
6. **2 min** The resulting list of rules is your Definition of Done. Make sure it's visible for everyone during the Sprint. For

example, put it next to the Sprint Backlog.

Our Findings With Facilitation

- We often encourage teams to generate more rules for the "Max Specs"-part. This drives more creative and less obvious rules that may end up being super important. At the same time, we always encourage teams to be more minimalistic during the "Min Specs"-round
- When your team really struggles to remove items from the "Max Specs", you can do another fifth round, but with new groups.
- It is better to end with two, three, or maybe four clear rules that people will absolutely adhere to than to generate a list of a dozen abstract principles.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "Min Specs" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Use 'Min Specs' to help groups discover what is absolutely essential](#)



Step 5: Closing

With this workshop, you familiarized your team with the concept of a Definition of Done and helped them create the first version of their own. With their Definition of Done, they can deliver the necessary quality to build a kick-ass product!

If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!

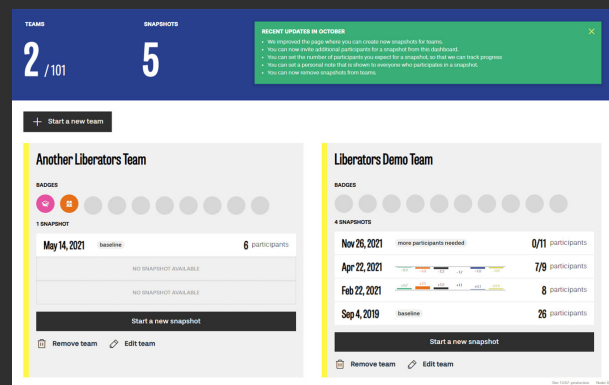
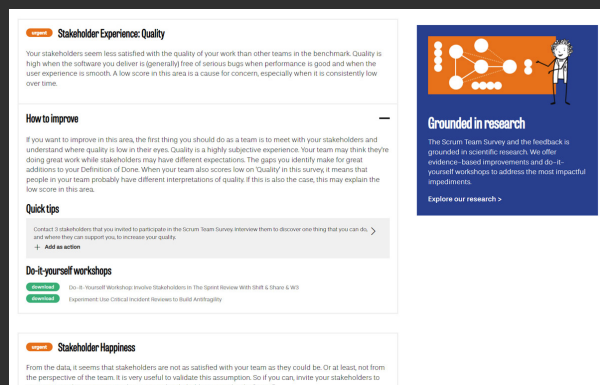
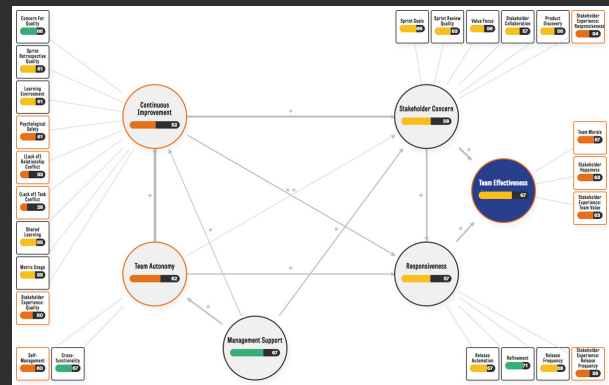
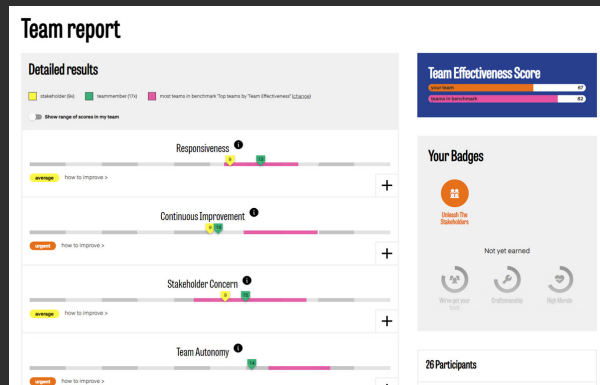


Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
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Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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